books of the three main monotheistic religions – the Devas were assailed by their demonic rivals the Asuras, who wreaked havoc on earth. It was known among the gods that only a pure virgin girl could defeat them so Bhumi Devi, Mother Earth, appealed to Parashakti, the Divine Mother, to intercede on her behalf. The Devas performed a *yajna*, or fire sacrifice, and out of the fire pit emerged a young virgin. She then travelled to the southern tip of India and settled there, hence the name Kanyakumari, or 'virgin adolescent girl'.

At this point the great god of yogis Lord Shiva appeared on the scene, saw the virgin goddess, fell in love and determined to marry her. A marriage was arranged, to take place at midnight at the close of a particularly auspicious day. But a divine sage then realised that the Asuras could be destroyed only if Kanyakumari remained a virgin. He therefore intervened by assuming the form of a rooster and crowing as Lord Shiva approached just before the midnight hour. Hearing the cock crow at what he mistook for the approaching dawn, Shiva concluded that he had come too late and had missed his chance. So Shiva returned to his abode in the Himalayas, and Kanyakumari, believing that she had been jilted, was plunged into grief. She tore her hair, broke her bracelets and anklets and scattered what was to have been their wedding feast far and wide – particles of which make up the multi-coloured sands and pebbles found along the southern seashore. She then became an ascetic, vowing to perform austerities until such time as Lord Shiva returned for her. Hence Devi Kanyakumari's exalted position as patroness of yogis and ascetics.

Delightful as this story is, it is just one of many variations on the theme of local female deities being absorbed into the Shaiva canon. Devi Kanyakumari goes back a lot further than her failed alliance with the Great God Shiva. Despite her virginity, she is part of a much older form of religious